ministries is probably due to religious reluctance. As for homophobia, despite the seriousness of the issue, one could not keep a straight face after Netanyahu appointed the gay Likudnik Amir Ohana as chairman of the Knesset: each time he arose to speak, the Orthodox members turned their heads in an opposite direction and covered their eyes … that's the Israeli parliament in 2023.

Today Smotrich announced that the building of new settlements would be hastened. Given American and French warnings, this is quite a test for the boss.

Biden's State of the Union speech can be read in two ways regarding the Israeli situation. On the one hand, the president barely touched on foreign policy and the situation in the Middle East was not mentioned. On the other hand, he did not cease to sing the praises of democracy. Israel was probably not on his mind, but the subject may come up if and when he invites Netanyahu to meet him. In any case, Blinken and others will not forget.

## *Wednesday, February 8*

There is a basic problem that I have postponed addressing, partly because it is so complex: Israel aims at being Jewish and democratic. Let me deal with it in very simplistic terms. Even at first glance, the conjunction is impossible, a contradiction in terms: the Arab citizens of Israel do not have the same rights as Jewish ones. De jure, they do not have a "Law of Return"; de facto, they do not have conditions identical to those of the Jewish population in many domains of daily life. Of course, this could be improved, but tacit solidarity with the Palestinians from the Occupied Territories will remain a dominant emotion for a majority of the Arab population and thus, the argument goes, full de facto rights would be dangerous. Thus, for as long as the conflict persists, Israel has to be Jewish and only very partially democratic. And, if the present government fulfills